

Foreword

We are surrounded by fascinating animals. Gigantic whales and sharks swim in the oceans. Spectacular large animals—such as big cats, elephants and giraffes—live on the land. Wild places everywhere are filled with insects, birds, and thousands of other living things. But Earth's fossil record shows us that these creatures are just the tips of an amazing hidden tree of life that stretches back hundreds of millions of years into the distant past. This rich fossil record tells us an incredible and complicated story of evolution and extinction. While modern animals may well be fascinating, those of the past were often bigger, stronger, or much, much weirder.

In this beautifully illustrated book, we look in detail at the huge variety of animal life that has evolved over the past 500 million years or so, from the origins of complex life in the Precambrian age to the dinosaurs of the Mesozoic Era and the mammals and birds of more modern times.

Most of the world's fossils represent the remains of small creatures like shellfish and plankton. But others show us that incredible beasts—sometimes very different from living animals—once existed as well. We know of crocodile-sized millipedes, horse-eating giant birds, monstrous sea reptiles, and bizarre mammals like ground sloths and saber-toothed cats. Figuring out what these animals looked like when alive has often been a difficult challenge, and scientists and artists have worked hard to reconstruct their appearance and behavior.

In this book you will see many spectacular illustrations of these animals and many others, all arranged in their evolutionary families and roughly in the order in which they appeared. Opening this book is like stepping back in time. Get ready to go on a spectacular visual tour of the animal life of the past, and prepare to be amazed.

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